

# Voices of Freedom, Voices of Change

**Essential question:** How can storytelling expose injustice and inspire change?

## Our theme and why we chose it

We want to focus on racial bias in the justice system, especially how Black young people can be seen as guilty or dangerous before anyone hears their full story. In *Punching the Air*, Amal is an artist and a teenager, but other people often reduce him to an accusation. That feels unfair and important to talk about. Our project asks visitors to look past a label and listen to a person.

## Three poems from the book

| Poem                            | Connection to theme                                                                        | Use in our project                                                        |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>"Blind Justice"</b><br>p. 44 | Amal questions whether justice is truly blind when race and neighborhood affect treatment. | The comic contrasts the choices offered to different young people.        |
| <b>"Gray Suit"</b><br>p. 9      | A change in appearance cannot remove the bias Amal faces in court.                         | The website asks what people notice first: the person or an image of him. |
| <b>"Black Ink"</b><br>p. 20     | Amal contrasts labels applied to him with labels applied to a white boy.                   | A side-by-side section shows how labels change a story.                   |

Page numbers follow the supplied planning presentation and may vary by edition. The website uses brief excerpts and paraphrases, not full poems.

## What we are making

We will make a public website called **More Than a Label**. It will include an About page, an Issue Overview page, a Connection to *Punching the Air* page, and a Comic page. The comic page will show our new color comic strip and include a text panel guide.

## Comic strip plan

1. Show a young person before any accusation or label.
2. Show the limited "jail or death" choices described in "Blind Justice."
3. Contrast those choices with the American Dream others are promised.
4. Let the character speak back to the unfair story being told about him.
5. End by asking readers to hear a person's whole story before judging them.

## Research and action

**Equal Justice Initiative:** Connect the history of racial injustice to current punishment. [eji.org/racial-justice](http://eji.org/racial-justice)

**Innocence Project:** Learn how racial bias contributes to wrongful convictions.

[innocenceproject.org/race-and-wrongful-conviction](http://innocenceproject.org/race-and-wrongful-conviction)

**Georgia Innocence Project:** Show a local organization working to correct and prevent wrongful convictions.

[georgiainnocenceproject.org/about](http://georgiainnocenceproject.org/about)